DG INTERN HUB

SOC ANALYST INTERNSHIP

WEEK 2 —NOTES

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MITRE ATT&CK — Tactics and Techniques

1. What are Tactics in MITRE ATT&CK?

Tactics explain **why an attacker is doing something**.

They represent the main goal of the attacker during an attack. For example, an attacker may want to get initial access to a system, steal credentials, or collect information.

Some common tactics are:

- Initial Access
- Execution
- Persistence
- Privilege Escalation
- Defense Evasion
- Credential Access
- Discovery
- Lateral Movement
- Collection
- Command and Control
- Exfiltration
- Impact

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2. What are Techniques?

Techniques explain **how the attacker is trying to achieve the goal**.

For example, if the attacker's goal is to get into an organization through phishing, then **Phishing** is the technique used to achieve the Initial Access tactic.

Techniques give more detail about the actual behaviour of the attacker.

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3. Difference between Tactics and Techniques

Tactics	*Techniques*
*Explain **why** the attacker is doing something*	*Explain **how** the attacker is doing it*
Represent the attacker's goal	*Represent the method used*
Higher-level category	*More specific behaviour*
Example: Initial Access	*Example: Phishing*
Helps understand the attacker's objective	*Helps understand the actual attack method*

Simple example

If an attacker sends a fake login email to an employee:

Tactic: Initial Access
Technique: Phishing

So, **Initial Access is the goal**, while **Phishing is the method used to reach that goal**.

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4. Enterprise Tactics and Example Techniques

The MITRE ATT&CK Enterprise Matrix contains different tactics that describe the goals attackers may have while targeting enterprise environments.

Enterprise Tactic	*What it means*	*Example Technique*

Reconnaissance	*Attacker collects information about the target before attacking*	*Active Scanning*
Resource Development	*Attacker prepares resources needed for an attack*	*Acquire Infrastructure*
Initial Access	*Attacker tries to enter the target environment*	*Phishing*
Execution	*Attacker tries to run malicious commands or code*	*Command and Scripting Interpreter*
Persistence	*Attacker tries to maintain access to the system*	*Scheduled Task/Job*
Privilege Escalation	*Attacker tries to get higher permissions*	*Exploitation for Privilege Escalation*
Defense Evasion	*Attacker tries to avoid detection*	*Indicator Removal*
Credential Access	*Attacker tries to obtain passwords or other credentials*	*OS Credential Dumping*
Discovery	*Attacker looks for information about systems and networks*	*Network Service Scanning*
Lateral Movement	*Attacker tries to move from one system to another*	*Remote Services*
Collection	*Attacker gathers useful information from the environment*	*Data from Local System*
Command and Control	*Attacker communicates with compromised systems*	*Application Layer Protocol*
Exfiltration	*Attacker tries to take data out of the environment*	*Exfiltration Over C2 Channel*

Impact	*Attacker tries to damage systems or affect availability*	*Data Encrypted for Impact*

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5. Example of Tactic and Technique in a SOC Alert

Suppose a SOC analyst receives an alert that a user received a suspicious email containing a link to a fake login page.

The analyst can look at the activity and identify:

- **Tactic:** Initial Access
- **Technique:** Phishing
- **Possible activity:** User received a malicious email
- **Investigation:** Check sender, URL, domain, email headers and whether the user clicked the link.

Another example could be PowerShell.

If a suspicious PowerShell command is executed on a Windows machine:

- **Tactic:** Execution
- **Technique:** Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell
- **Investigation:** Check the command, parent process, user account, timestamp and other related logs.

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6. Why is this useful for a SOC analyst?

I think the main advantage is that it gives the analyst a better way to understand an alert.

Instead of only saying:

> "PowerShell was executed."

The analyst can think:

> "Why was PowerShell executed, what was it doing, and does this behaviour match an ATT&CK technique?"

This helps the analyst investigate the alert with more context.

It can also help with:

- Creating detection rules
- Threat hunting
- Investigating suspicious activity
- Understanding attacker behaviour
- Connecting multiple alerts together
- Improving SOC detection coverage

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7. My Understanding

The main thing I understood from this topic is that **Tactics and Techniques are not the same thing**.

Tactics tell us **what the attacker wants to achieve**, while techniques tell us **how the attacker is trying to achieve it**.

For a SOC analyst, this is useful because when I see a suspicious activity in logs, I can try to understand what the attacker is trying to do instead of looking at that event separately.

For example, if I find suspicious PowerShell activity, I can investigate the command and other related events and then map the behaviour to the relevant ATT&CK technique.

This can make the investigation more structured and easier to understand.